

Aakansha Jain

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EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Economics, Iowa State University, USA	May 2027 (expected)
M.Sc. in Economics, Shiv Nadar University, India	2020
B.Sc. in Economics, University of Calcutta, India (Minor: Mathematics & Statistics; First-Class Honours)	2017

FIELDS OF INTEREST

Labor Economics, Agricultural Labor, Development Economics, Rural Development, Economics of Education, Migration, Applied Microeconomics

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

Manternach, R., **Jain, A.**, Orazem, P.F., & Soborowicz, L. (2025). “Are College Towns Really Recession Proof?” *Growth and Change*, 56(4): e70064.

Book Chapters

Jain, A., Montenegro, C., & Orazem, P.F. (forthcoming, 2026). “Youth Labor Markets in High- and Low-Income Countries.” In K. Leicht (Ed.), *Oxford University Handbook on the 21st Century Economy*. Oxford University Press.

WORKING PAPERS

“The Rise of H-2A: Causal Evidence on Guestworker Substitution for Settled Farm Labor”

Job Market Paper; solo-authored

Certified positions under the H-2A agricultural guestworker program grew more than fourfold between 2008 and 2024, while the settled non-citizen farm workforce shrank under intensified immigration enforcement. Using a panel of 740 commuting zones and shift-share (Bartik) instruments built on national enforcement shocks, I show that farms hire approximately one H-2A guestworker for each settled worker lost, replacing about three quarters of the lost labor time. On the benchmark Border Patrol budget instrument, this substitution accounts for about 29 percent of H-2A growth since 2008.

“Returns to Farming Among Iowa State Alumni”

with I. Cho and P.F. Orazem

Compares the household income of farmers and observationally similar nonfarm workers among Iowa State University graduates, using matching estimators and an endogenous treatment effects model. Farmers earn significantly less, even though household income includes off-farm earnings. Among all farmers the gap is concentrated in nonrural households; among full-time farmers it holds in rural areas as well.

“College Wage Premiums in India: Trends and Spatial Decomposition, 1987–2012”

solo-authored

Traces the college wage premium across five waves of India’s National Sample Survey, 1987–2012, a period when tertiary enrollment nearly tripled. The premium rose throughout, and zone-level decompositions show that the young–old premium gap closed where college supply expanded most.

[“An Overview of the 2024 Iowa State University Alumni Survey”](#)

with A. Andrade, J. Eyles, K. Kimle, P.F. Orazem, and R. Unal

Documents the design, sample construction, and descriptive findings of the 2024 Iowa State University alumni survey, covering graduating cohorts from 1982 to 2023 with over 5,000 usable responses. The primary data reference for subsequent work drawing on the survey.

WORKS IN PROGRESS

[“Does Broadband Close the Rural Education Gap?”](#)

with L. Han and J.V. Winters

Asks whether federally subsidized broadband raises college enrollment among rural high-school graduates. The Connect America Fund Phase II set block eligibility ex ante through an FCC cost model and deployed in stages over 2015–2021, leaving nearly half of eligible blocks unserved as controls. A staggered difference-in-differences design with block and cohort fixed effects links deployment records to restricted American Community Survey microdata.

[“Firm Entry and Serial Entrepreneurship Among Iowa State Alumni”](#)

with D. Lin and P.F. Orazem

Examines how labor market conditions at graduation shape entrepreneurial entry among Iowa State University alumni across the 2008 and 2024 alumni surveys. A higher Iowa unemployment rate at graduation delays business entry for about a decade, after which the effect fades; national conditions show no such effect. Over a full career, family and social ties to business ownership predict who becomes an entrepreneur.

POLICY REPORTS

- **Jain, A.**, Lin, D., & Orazem, P.F. (forthcoming, Nov 2026). “Graduating in a Downturn: Business Cycles and Entrepreneurship Among Iowa State Graduates.” *Agricultural Policy Review*, Fall 2026. Center for Agricultural and Rural Development, Iowa State University.
- **Jain, A.**, & Chandio, R. (forthcoming, Nov 2026). “Who Hires H-2A Workers in Iowa, and for What?” *Agricultural Policy Review*, Fall 2026. Center for Agricultural and Rural Development, Iowa State University.
- Crespi, G., & **Jain, A.** (2026). [“Where Do They Go? Migration Patterns of Iowa State University Alumni.”](#) *Agricultural Policy Review*, Winter 2026. Center for Agricultural and Rural Development, Iowa State University.
- Andrade, A., Eyles, J., **Jain, A.**, Kimle, K., Orazem, P.F., & Unal, R. (2025). [“How a Land Grant College Affects Business and Job Creation.”](#) *Agricultural Policy Review*, Fall 2025. Center for Agricultural and Rural Development, Iowa State University.

PUBLIC ENGAGEMENT

Media Mentions

- [“Iowa State college graduates left for bigger cities, but they’re returning to Iowa.”](#) *Axios Des Moines*, April 21, 2026. Coverage of Crespi and Jain (2026).

Outreach Writing

- **Jain, A.** (2024). [“How to Compute Real Income or Real Value of a Given Currency?”](#) *Ask an Economist* (public question-and-answer column), Department of Economics, Iowa State University, November 6, 2024.

CONFERENCES AND PRESENTATIONS

- Southern Economic Association (SEA) Annual Meeting, Houston, TX Nov 2026

Selected Paper: "The Rise of H-2A: Causal Evidence on Guestworker Substitution for Settled Farm Labor"

- Agricultural & Applied Economics Association (AAEA) South Asia Section Graduate Student Symposium (virtual) Oct 2026
Selected Paper: "The Rise of H-2A: Causal Evidence on Guestworker Substitution for Settled Farm Labor"
- USDA Agricultural Marketing Service, FAME 2.0 Release Webinar (virtual) Oct 2026
Invited Speaker: how our first-place challenge team used FAME data (with A. Basha and H. Lee)
- AAEA Annual Meeting, Kansas City, MO Jul 2026
Selected Paper: "The Rise of H-2A: Causal Evidence on Guestworker Substitution for Settled Farm Labor" Data Visualization Challenge: "Mapping the Missing Market Pathways in U.S. Dairy Regions" (with A. Basha and H. Lee)
- Midwest Economics Association Annual Meeting, Chicago, IL Mar 2025
"Are College Towns Really Recession Proof?"

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Standalone Instructor, Iowa State University

ECON 3530: Money, Banking, and Financial Institutions Spring 2025

- Designed and delivered a full-semester course for 60 students in a subject outside my primary field, building the syllabus, lecture content, and all assessments.
- Administered homework and weekly quizzes through Pearson MyLab and Canvas; coordinated a teaching assistant for review sessions and grading.
- Learned to design courses for undergraduate audiences: aligning assessments with lectures, keeping grades visible, and pacing material to the class.

Teaching Assistant, Iowa State University

ECON 1020: Principles of Macroeconomics Spring 2026, Fall 2023

ECON 2070: Quantitative Methods in Economic Analysis I Fall 2025

ECON 3530: Money, Banking, and Financial Institutions Fall 2024

ECON 1010: Principles of Microeconomics (lab and online sections) Fall 2022 – Winter 2024

- Led recitations, weekly quantitative labs, and pre-exam review sessions across principles and intermediate courses; designed and graded quizzes and exams.
- Ran fully online and accelerated sections, including a one-month asynchronous course with recorded review sessions, live Q&A, and virtual office hours.
- A faculty observer highlighted my success in getting students to answer questions in class, and course evaluations included requests for more of my instruction.

Teaching Assistant, Shiv Nadar University, India

Econometrics (graduate course) Spring 2021

Logic and Scientific Methods (undergraduate course) Fall 2018

- Tutored 20 graduate students and 30 undergraduates one-on-one; graded assignments.

Mentorship

Tutor, "Economics Help Room" Spring 2023 – Fall 2024

- Tutored undergraduates one-on-one in the department's drop-in tutoring center, across principles and intermediate courses.
- Ranked among the top 3 of 25 teaching assistants (Fall 2024) with the top supervisor rating.

Graduate Mentor, “Saturday Morning Breakfast Club”	Spring 2023 – Present
• Mentor undergraduates through their own research projects in the department’s weekly undergraduate research program: framing research questions, finding data sources, building datasets, and writing replicable Stata code. • Breakfast Club collaborations produced papers listed above, including a <i>Growth and Change</i> article with an undergraduate first author and an <i>Agricultural Policy Review</i> article with an undergraduate coauthor.	
RESEARCH EXPERIENCE	
Research Assistant, Iowa State University	
Department of Economics (multiple appointments)	Spring 2024 – Present
• Iowa State University Alumni Survey project with Peter F. Orazem: built the 2024 survey data pipeline from raw Qualtrics responses (Summer 2024), constructed rural–urban migration measures across graduating cohorts (Summer 2025), and currently work quarter-time on alumni entrepreneurship and the returns to farming (Fall 2026). • Beginning agricultural extension work with Rabail Chandio (Fall 2026). • Contributed to the empirical analysis of “Are College Towns Really Recession Proof?” (<i>Growth and Change</i>, 2025) and supported the undergraduate researchers on the project (Spring 2024).	
Research Assistant, India	
Indian School of Business, Hyderabad	Summer 2022
• Contributed to a pilot randomized controlled trial evaluating India’s food-subsidy program (the Public Distribution System) in the state of Bihar; managed survey logistics and data cleaning.	
IFMR LEAD (development research center)	Aug 2021 – Mar 2022
• Analyzed differential impacts of COVID-19 on the mental well-being of men and women using difference-in-differences; conducted data analysis in Stata and geocoding with the Google Maps API. Principal investigators: Amrita Dhillon and Sanchari Roy (King’s College London) and Farzana Afridi (Indian Statistical Institute, Delhi).	
King’s College London (project based in India)	Jun 2020 – Jul 2021
• Developed composite measures of Indian states’ performance under two national programs, the rural employment guarantee (MGNREGA) and the rural roads program (PMGSY); supervised a team of research assistants for quality control of a large administrative dataset. Principal investigators: Amrita Dhillon (King’s College London), Farzana Afridi (Indian Statistical Institute, Delhi), and Arka Roy Chaudhury (Shiv Nadar University).	
HONORS AND AWARDS	
Selected Paper (\$200 award), AAEA South Asia Section Graduate Student Symposium	2026
First Place, USDA Agricultural Marketing Service and AAEA Local Food Economics Data Visualization Challenge	2026
• “Mapping the Missing Market Pathways in U.S. Dairy Regions,” with A. Basha and H. Lee (GitHub Repository); \$1,200 first-place team prize and \$1,200 in AAEA travel support.	
PROFESSIONAL SERVICE	
Referee: <i>Growth and Change</i> ; <i>Journal of Development Effectiveness</i>	

Conferences

Discussant, Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting	Nov 2026
Discussant, AAEA South Asia Section Graduate Student Symposium	Oct 2026
Session Moderator, Agricultural & Applied Economics Association Annual Meeting	Jul 2026
Discussant, Midwest Economics Association Annual Meeting	Mar 2025

University

Elected Chair, College of Liberal Arts and Sciences, Graduate & Professional Student Senate	2023 – 2024
Senator, Department of Economics, Graduate & Professional Student Senate	2023 – 2024

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

Mentee, Association for Mentoring and Inclusion in Economics (AMIE)	2025 – 2026
Preparing Future Faculty Course (GRST 5850), Iowa State University	Fall 2025

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

American Economic Association; Agricultural & Applied Economics Association; Midwest Economics Association

CORE COMPETENCIES

Technical Skills

Software: Stata, Python, L^AT_EX, Google Maps API (geocoding)

Data: IPUMS (CPS, ACS, Decennial Census), USDA Census of Agriculture, U.S. Department of Labor H-2A administrative records, Iowa State University Alumni Survey, India's National Sample Survey, India's District Information System for Education

Methods: Panel data, difference-in-differences, shift-share (Bartik) instrumental variables, event study, regression discontinuity, randomized controlled trial design and evaluation

Restricted Data: Special Sworn Status, U.S. Census Bureau; approved Federal Statistical Research Data Center (FSRDC) project (No. 3044) with access to restricted American Community Survey and Social Security Numident microdata through the Iowa State FSRDC

Outside Economics: Machine Learning: A Signal Processing Perspective (EE 425)

Transferable Skills

Building survey data pipelines from raw responses; supervising research-assistant teams on data quality; mentoring student research projects to publication; writing policy articles for non-academic audiences; designing and teaching a full course

Languages: English (fluent), Hindi (native)

REFERENCES

Dr. John V. Winters
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Iowa State University
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Dr. Peter F. Orazem
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